

We've been discussing the free will defense as a response to the argument from evil. This response assumes something about us: that we have free will.

But what does this mean?

To say that we have free will is to say that some of our actions are up to us; it is to say that, at least sometimes, we have the ability to choose what we do.

Is it true that some of our actions are up to us, and that we sometimes are able to choose what we will do?

But before doing that it is worth asking why there is any reason to accept the common view that we do have free will. Are there any arguments in favor of the reality of free will?

There are. The first argument starts with an apparent fact about moral responsibility: it seems that we are only responsible for actions which we freely perform or which stem from actions we freely perform. If you find out that someone's action was not done of their own free will, then it would be odd to blame them for their action.

But it also seems that people are at least sometimes genuinely responsible for their actions.

This suggests the following simple argument:

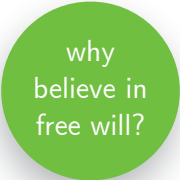
The question we'll be asking ourselves for the next two weeks is: do we have free will? Our discussion will involve us considering the three strongest arguments **against** the view that we have free will.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

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first let's think about how Edwards'

responding to Edwards' argument. But

for fatalsn.

argument might be related to an argument

We'll shortly consider some ways of

there were truths about all our future

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

similar to Edwards' argument?

actions. Could they give an argument

Suppose that someone did not believe in

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

with reference to the being of truth about

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

replace reference to God's foreknowledge



all of our activities.

God knows that in the future I will

1. We have no direct facts.

2*In the past, there were truths about

then we have the choice about q.

0 We have achieved what we

3 We have not the fact that

that if it is true that I will perform

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,



acaioid.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

5* We have noticed that the fact

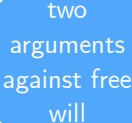
will perform various actions.

perform a certain action (1,2)

some action, then I will prefer that

(3, 4, 5)

The fatalist argument



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Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

involves considering the strongest arguments against the view that we have

This is the question we'll be asking ourselves for the next two weeks. Our discussion will

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